



HOW SINGULARLY INNOCENT I LOOK THIS MORNING

LAURA / 1944

IN CONTEXT

GENRE

Film noir, romance

DIRECTOR

Otto Preminger

WRITERS

Jay Dratler, Samuel Hoffenstein, Elizabeth Reinhardt (screenplay); Vera Caspary (novel)

STARS

Gene Tierney, Dana Andrews, Clifton Webb

BEFORE

1940 Tierney makes her screen debut in Fritz Lang's *The Return of Frank James*.

AFTER

1955 Preminger's *The Man With the Golden Arm* deals with drug addiction, one of several controversial topics that he will tackle.

1959 In *Anatomy of a Murder*, Preminger depicts rape more frankly than it had ever been shown in Hollywood movies.

Although it is synonymous with film noir, *Laura* works best when viewed as a twisted romance. Otto Preminger's movie plays out as a love triangle within a murder mystery, as New York detective Mark McPherson (Dana Andrews) falls for the title character (Gene Tierney), a beautiful advertising executive apparently gunned down on her doorstep at the start.

McPherson's investigation checks all the requisite boxes for a gumshoe movie—Laura's wayward playboy beau, her two-faced aunt, and her overprotective best friend—but Preminger adds a strange, dreamlike quality to the movie. The femme-fatale formula is slightly subverted: Tierney plays Laura as an unwitting siren, unaware of the spell she is casting.

The movie's witty script still sparkles today, and it features a sumptuous original score by David Raksin, whose main theme became a jazz standard. ■



Writer Waldo Lydecker (Clifton Webb, center) and playboy Shelby Carpenter (Vincent Price) are two of the suspicious men in Laura's life.

What else to watch: *Leave Her To Heaven* (1945) ■ *The Killers* (1946) ■ *Build My Gallows High* (1947, p.332) ■ *Anatomy of a Murder* (1959)